

Hiranayaksha uses strength to overcome his discontent and become all-powerful. Hiranakashipu uses cunning. The Asuras who follow, Virochan and Bali, use generosity to win the affection of subjects to achieve the same end. While Hiranayaksha and Hiranakashipu are self-absorbed, Virochan and Bali are concerned about others. This indicates growth. Unlike Hiranayaksha and Hiranakashipu who exclude others, Virochan and Bali include others. Though Asuras, they are revered in the scriptures.

But still, the focus of Virochan and Bali remains 'what I have' rather than 'what I am'. They feel that happiness comes when material needs are met. They fail to realise that as long as man is in Maya, material needs can never be fully satisfied. Contentment comes only when material growth is accompanied by spiritual growth.

Virochan is Prahalad's son. And like all stories of Asuras, he becomes very powerful until Vishnu comes to him in the form of Mohini and secures a gift from him. 'Whatever you wish,' says Virochan. Mohini immediately asks him for his head. Virochan, true to his word, severs his neck, to the delight of the Devas.

Virochan's son, Bali, becomes more powerful than any other Asura before him. And like his father, he is very generous. This makes Bali a very popular Asura. In his realm there is prosperity everywhere. His fame spreads far and wide and in time eclipses even the glory of the Devas. Humans turn to Bali with reverence





and eventually even Sachi leaves Indra's side to sit beside the wise and noble Bali. So great is Bali that in his kingdom everything is perfect; all needs are satisfied and all wants are met; there is no disease or death. People conclude that Bali must be God. Even Bali comes to believe that he is God, after all he can give everyone whatever they desire.

That is when Vishnu approaches Bali as a dwarf or Vaman. 'Whatever you wish shall be yours,' says Bali. Vaman asks for three paces of land. Without a thought, Bali agrees to give what Vaman wants. But Shukra, advisor to Bali, recognises Vishnu. He tells Bali to hold back, but Bali refuses to go back on his word.

To complete the act of charity, Bali has to ritually pour water from the snout of his water pot. To block the ritual, Shukra reduces his size, enters the pot and blocks the snout. Vishnu divines what Shukra is up to and so when no water comes out of the pot, he offers to unclog the snout. Vishnu takes a blade of grass, sharpens it end and shoves it up the snout, blinding Shukra in one eye. Shukra leaps out of pot howling in pain and water gushes out from the snout. The ritual is thus completed and Vaman is officially entitled to three paces of land.

Vaman then, right before Bali's eyes, transforms into a giant and with one stride claims the sky and with another stride claims the earth. 'I have no other place to place my foot now,' says Vishnu in a voice that booms across the three worlds. Bali, overwhelmed by the sight of the giant Vishnu, bows his head humbly and replies, 'Please place it on my head then.' Vishnu places his head on Bali's head and shoves him under the ground, into Patala, the subterranean world that is the rightful place of Asuras.

All those who see this gigantic form of Vishnu conclude that





only Vishnu is Trivikrama, conqueror of the three worlds of the Devas, the Manavas and the Asuras. He spans all worlds. He is God.

Bali is a good king who, like his father, assumes that if he satisfies the desires of all living creatures, all will be well. By transforming into a giant, Vishnu draws Bali's attention to a reality that Bali ignores: human desires are infinite while material resources are finite. Bali can never satisfy all the desires of living creatures. Material resources are limited but human want is unlimited. To make Bali realise this, Vaman turns into a giant. Before Vaman's gigantic form, Bali realises his insignificance.